

The Smooth Operator

Project management means overseeing the web woven from deadlines, resources, interdependencies, schedules... you know. Thankfully, we have software dedicated to charting it all

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There's software for everything—whether it's controlling a rocket-propelled spaceship or a coffee machine. There's software for getting in control, getting on top of things, organising things... but you know that. What we're saying is that even if there's something you need to get on top of—like a team project, a personal plan, a group activity—you can use, you guessed it, software!

Here, we're specifically talking about project management. People, resources, time, contingencies—there are parameters of various types at various levels to be in control of. Now, if you're the born leader, manager, and communicator all rolled into one, it's easy—just do it in your head, or use Notepad. But ordinary people need... yes... software!

At this point, we should mention that it's natural for some people to think of Microsoft Project. It's not quite *de facto*, but a large number of people—especially those in enterprises—use it. (We're going to encourage you not to bother, with a couple of exceptions—we'll get to the reasons soon enough.)

One tool that could be useful—if the project is small enough—is a mind-mapping solution; after all, your fundamental agenda only consists of (a) thinking, and (b) communicating. Then, you could use a spreadsheet—for example, Excel as a small-project management tool. This is quite elementary, and is described at <http://tinyurl.com/yutoso>.

Now our agenda here is to talk about a free project management tool called GanttProject, which is really not much more than a productivity booster. But you need it to save on aspirin and to maintain your sanity. You'll have the comfort of starting up a program and saying something like "OK, so here's where we're placed. Now so-and-so is on leave tomorrow, so let me draw this little line... ah, still looks good." Much, much better than straightaway getting tense because so-and-so is on leave tomorrow.